

BY THE YEAR

2007 T-20, WOMAN PRESIDENT

Benazir Bhutto is assassinated. India win first ICC Twenty20 World Championship. Sunita Williams takes a walk in space. Narain Karthikeyan wins the AIGP race in Zuhai. Gujjars agitate for reservation in Rajasthan. Kiran Desai wins Man Booker Prize. Violent protests at Nandigram in West Bengal against government's land acquisition move. Pratibha Patil becomes the first woman President of India.

2008 26/11, NANO

Terrorists open fire in Mumbai killing nearly 200. Supreme Court upholds 27 per cent OBC quota in Central educational institutions. Tata Nano is launched. Lunar Mission Chandrayan I is successful. The Kosi floods Bihar. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh wins trust vote. Pakistan president Musharraf steps down. Sensex crashes to below 10,000. Abhinav Bindra wins Gold at Olympics.

2009 OBAMA, OSCARS

Slumdog Millionaire wins eight Oscars. Satyam scam surfaces. Swine flu breaks out. Barack Obama becomes US President. Government proposes to scrap Class X board exams. UPA is back in power. India-born V. Ramakrishnan shares Nobel Prize in Chemistry. Homosexuality is decriminalised. Tendulkar completes 20 years of international cricket. Liberhan Commission indicts 68, including Vajpayee, over Babri demolition.

keep on this path instead of being diverted into inaction or misdirected anti-reforms policies by calls for "social justice" from the people whose advocacy of the disastrous pre-reforms policy framework accentuated the very poverty they now accuse India of having ignored. Calls for social justice ring hollow when the policies one espoused led to its denial in practice by undermining the economic prospects of the poor.

But the success of the Stage 1 reforms, with its direct impact on poverty, can be supplemented by Stage 2 reforms now that a growing economy has finally begun to provide the revenues that can be spent on additionally helping the poor. The prime minister has remarked that, without revenues, he was handicapped from doing so. This is no longer so. The Stage 2 reforms are, in fact, particularly difficult because they involve "social engineering". Thus, if we are going to provide more effective access for the poor to primary and secondary education, we have to worry about absentee teachers, about the optimal size of classes, about the role of school vouchers for the poor, and other issues where there is a lot of controversy in most countries, not just in India. For higher education, we have the problem of reservations, an issue that raises questions about the best form of affirmative action. The Employment Guarantee Scheme is yet another way to spend the new monies on Stage 2 reforms. But here, there is even more controversy since there is the not-groundless fear that the monies will disappear into the pockets of politicians at the ground level, and that such schemes will produce more corruption instead of helping the poor.

These are the areas where we will see more

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research and then informed action. But it is surely the way ahead. Stage 2 reforms are sometimes presented as an alternative to Stage 1 reforms: a noted economist, whose embrace of the pre-reforms policy framework put us back by a generation in our efforts at reducing poverty, is fond of saying that we should worry about poverty and not about whether Coca-Cola should be allowed to invest in India. He could not be more wrong. It is not just that we are not like President Gerald Ford who could not do two things at one time. It is also that we need to do both. Stage 2 reforms are dependent on the success of Stage 1 reforms.

Fortunately, the prime minister understands this; but he needs to articulate it better. Just as he taught President Obama why India was on a better economic and political path than China, whom the President seemed to be in awe of, he can also learn from the President's eloquence and how to translate his profound grasp of what India needs in its economic policy framework into a bold vision to be put before the country. I believe that the reforms, by finally helping to reduce poverty, have led to the Revolution of Perceived Possibilities. As long as we were stagnant, there was fatalism. But now, aspirations have been aroused. The masses know that, while *Oliver Twist* asked for more and got less, they can ask for more and translate that into political demands at the voting booth. The poor are finally awake and want more results.

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Naxals
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Fusion food
Facebook
MMS
Size Zero
Six-pack abs
BlackBerry
BLING
Made in China
Cheerleaders
Sleeper cells
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iPods
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